Payroll and Hub Accounts System

Full explanation: what was built, how it is organised, who can do what, and a worked trial from an empty system

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In one paragraph. The business used about 55 weekly manager sheets, monthly manager sheets and one income sheet per guy in Excel. This system keeps the same ideas in one place: people are entered once, daily sales and settle-ups are typed or imported, payroll is calculated by fixed rules, unusual rows wait for a second person, and a finalized month is locked and produces payslips and a bank file. Everything is recorded in an audit trail.

1 What this system is

It is a web application for a direct-sales business in Jaffna. People sell through a chain of positions. At the end of each month the owner must work out what every person is paid, what each manager owes or is owed, and what stock is missing. Until now this was done in Excel workbooks.

What the Excel files did

Sheet	Purpose
Guy income sheet	One per person per month: daily business and settle-up, then a payslip block (target, commission, food, deductions, net).
Weekly manager master	One per manager per week: products sold, the manager's price (90% of list), deposit, rent, hub fee, security, personal draw, profit and balance.
Monthly manager sheet	Weekly figures totalled, an estimate of the guys' salaries, and the manager's month balance.
Cash and stock sheets	Deposits against what is due, office costs, branch reconciliation, and stock open, issue, sale and balance.

What went wrong with Excel

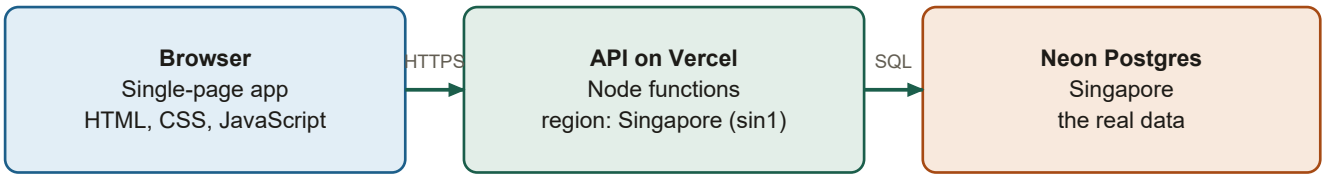
- Prices were typed into formulas and drifted. The 30W was 675 in some sheets and 2,385 in others, and one week showed two different business totals.
- A pay formula tested for the word "supervior" (misspelled). Typing "supervisor" correctly silently changed the target and basic pay.

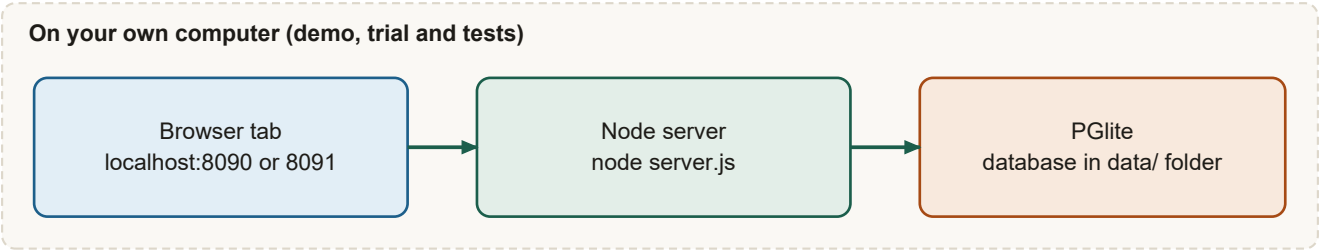
- The monthly guys-salary line used 8 different formulas across 21 sheets; 14 of them subtracted one guy's balance instead of the total.
- The 0.75 and 0.9 labels in each weekly master changed nothing; every sheet used 90% prices underneath.
- There was no record of who changed what, and no way to say a payment had been made.

What the system does instead

Need	How the system meets it
One list of people	Every person is entered once with a position, who they report to, their pay setup and bank details.
Pay rules written once	Targets, basic pay, commission, food and security are set per position and can still differ per person.
Fast entry	A day-by-day grid, a by-person grid, and CSV import for the daily sheets.
Checked results	Rows that break a rule wait in Approvals for a second person. The person who changed a bank account cannot approve it.
Closing a month	Finalizing locks every entry. Closing balances become next month's opening balances.
Outputs	Payslips, a payroll register (CSV), and a bank file.
Accountability	An audit trail records who changed what, with old and new values.

2 How it is built



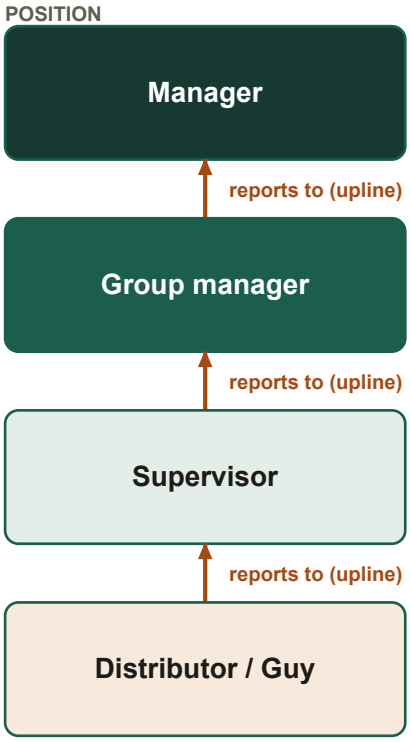


Part	What it is	Notes
Browser app	A single-page web app in plain JavaScript, no framework.	Light theme by default, dark theme on request, a sidebar that can shrink to icons, and layouts that work on a phone.
API	Node.js functions on Vercel, run in Singapore.	Every change must send a custom header, which stops other websites forging requests. Reads are limited to a person's hub where that applies.
Database	Postgres on Neon, in Singapore.	Money is stored as whole cents. Every change to a record is copied into the audit log by a database trigger.
Local mode	The same app on your computer using PGlite, a small embedded Postgres.	Used for the demo, the trial and the automated tests. Nothing local touches the hosted data.

Why two places? The hosted site is what people will use. The local demo and trial exist so you can try anything, break anything and start over without risk.

3 The hierarchy

People are organised as a chain. Each person has a **position** and a **reports to** (upline). Each person earns from their own sales; the chain records who belongs to whom so that team results and balances can be built from it.



WHAT THEY DO

Runs a hub (branch). Paid by the weekly business formula.

Top of the chain. Reports to no one.

Leads supervisors. Has a target and sells too.

Reports to the manager.

Leads distributors. Target 120,000 a month.

Reports to a group manager or manager.

Sells daily. Target 100,000 a month.

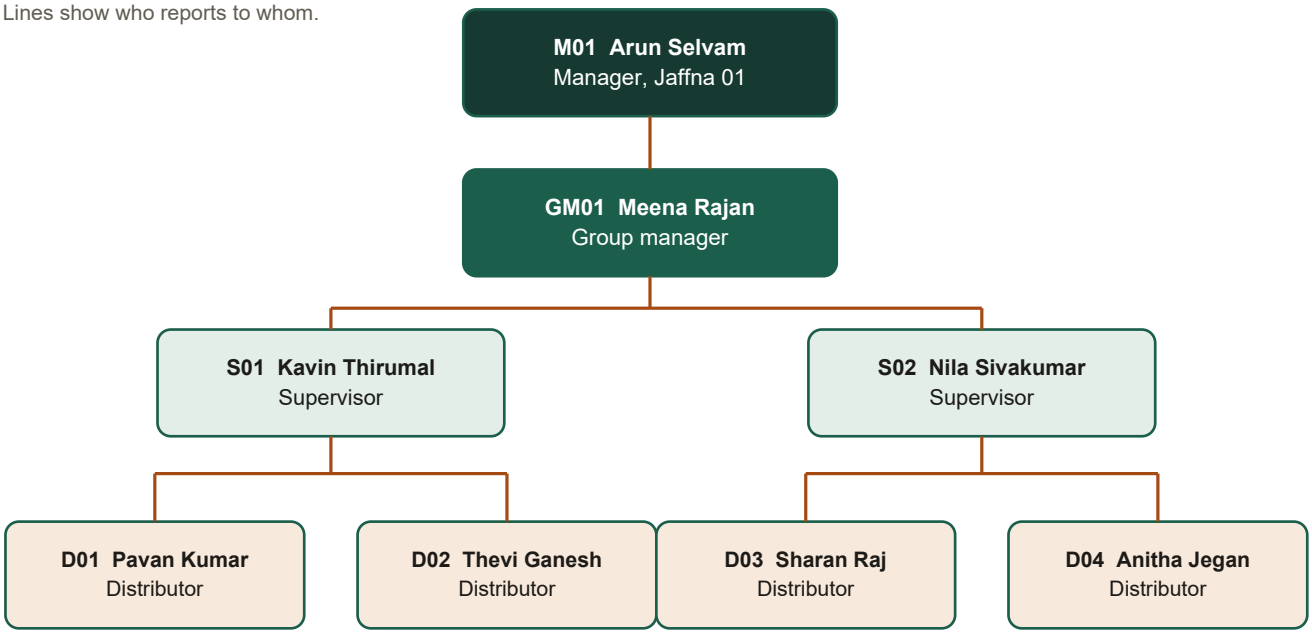
Reports to a supervisor or anyone above.

Rules the system enforces

- A person must report to someone **more senior**. A supervisor cannot report to a distributor, or to another supervisor.
- A manager is at the top and reports to no one.
- A person cannot report to themselves, and the chain can never loop.
- The **payroll manager** of a guy is found automatically by walking up the chain to the nearest manager.
- A hub manager (a login role, see section 4) can register people in their own hub, but cannot create or change a manager.
- When you choose a position while adding someone, the pay setup fills in from that position's defaults. You can still change it for that person.

Example: the Jaffna 01 group used in the trial

Lines show who reports to whom.



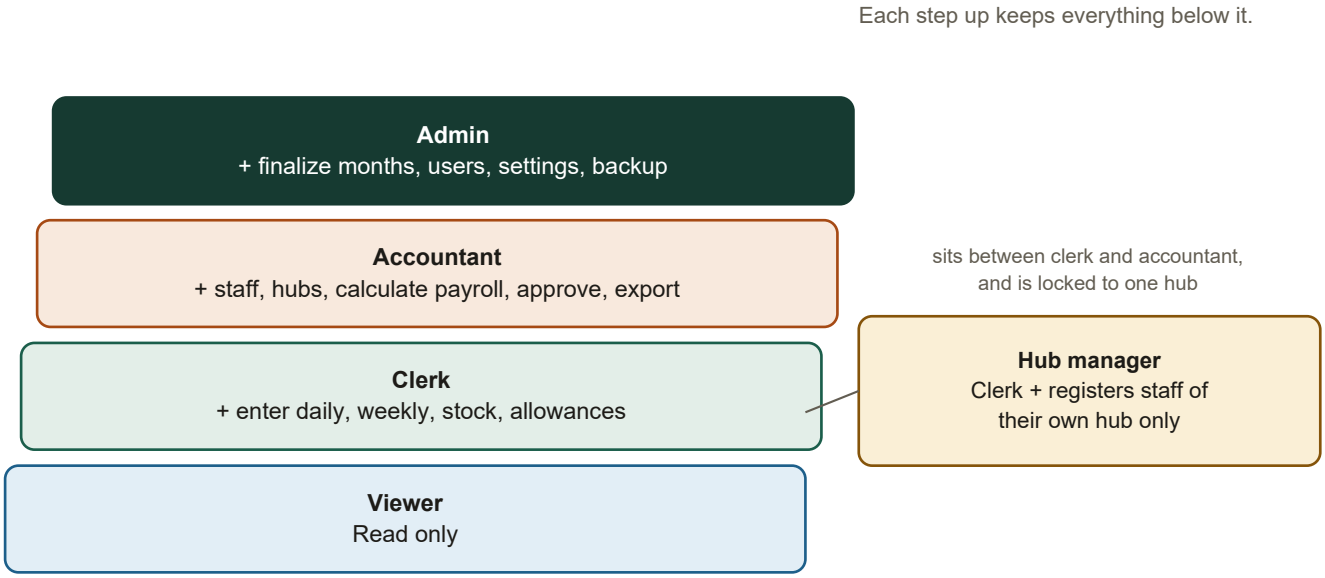
Position	Default target	Basic pay	Commission under target	Over target	Food	Security
Distributor	100,000	25,000	25% of all business	basic + 30% of the extra	150 a day, from day 1	1% of business
Supervisor	120,000	30,000	25% of all business	basic + 30% of the extra	150 a day if 24+ days	1% of business
Group manager	150,000	35,000	25% of all business	basic + 30% of the extra	150 a day if 24+ days	1% of business

The distributor and supervisor figures come from your Excel files. The group manager figures are placeholders until the owner confirms them. The defaults live in Settings, under Pay defaults by position.

Not built yet: team earnings. The chain is recorded, but a supervisor or manager does not yet earn a percentage of the people below them. The owner has not given the percentages or said whether a level earns the difference between rates or a full rate on top. The questionnaire documents ask exactly this.

4 User roles

A **login role** says what a person may do in the system. It is separate from their **position** in the chain. For example, a hub manager login belongs to a person who is also a Manager in the chain, but the two are stored separately.



What each role can do

Action	Viewer	Clerk	Hub mgr	Accountant	Admin
Read dashboards, sheets, payroll, reports	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Enter daily, weekly, stock, allowances	–	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Register and edit staff	–	–	Own hub, never a manager	Yes	Yes
Add and edit hubs	–	–	–	Yes	Yes
Calculate payroll, approve flagged rows	–	–	–	Yes	Yes
Download register CSV and bank file	–	–	–	Yes	Yes
Finalize (lock) a month	–	–	–	–	Yes
Add users, change roles	–	–	–	–	Yes
Change settings, download backup	–	–	–	–	Yes

Limiting a login to one hub

A clerk or hub manager can be tied to one hub. They then see only that hub's people, sheets, payroll rows and dashboard, and the system refuses any change for another hub. A hub manager must always have a hub.

Safeguards

- **Second person:** the person who changed a bank account cannot approve the payment to it.
- **Sign-in:** passwords need 8 or more characters with letters and numbers; five wrong attempts lock the username for a while; sessions last 12 hours.
- **Locked months:** once finalized, no entry for that month can be added, changed or deleted.
- **Audit:** changes, approvals, finalizing, settings changes and bank-file downloads are recorded with the user and time.

Logins on the local demo

Role	Username	Password	Hub
Admin	admin	admin123	all
Accountant	accounts	accounts123	all
Hub manager	manager1, manager2, manager3	manager123	Jaffna 01, 02, 03
Clerk	clerk	clerk123	Jaffna 01
Viewer	viewer	viewer123	all

These work only on the local demo (npm run demo). The hosted site uses its own accounts with random passwords that were shown once when the demo data was loaded; they are deliberately not printed here.

5 Every screen

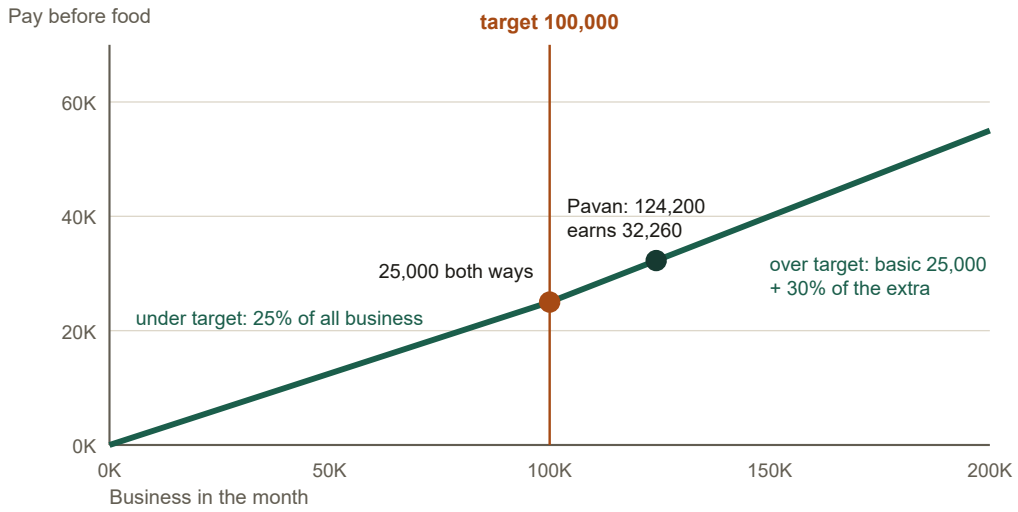
Group	Screen	What it is for	Who
Overview	Dashboard	Business, gross payroll, amount to the bank, settle-up and stock shortfall, managers' balance, a six-month trend and business by hub.	All roles
Data entry	Daily sheet	Business, settled amount and personal minus per person per day. Day-by-day or by-person grids, CSV import and export. Settle-up minus is worked out automatically.	All read; clerk and above enter
	Weekly sheet	One row per manager per week: business, profit %, rent, hub fee, security, personal draw. The weekly balance is shown as you type.	Enter data
	Stock count	Opening, issued, sold and counted stock with unit price. The shortfall and its value come off the person's pay.	Enter data
	Allowances	Extra earnings such as transport, added to a person's month.	Enter data
Payroll	Payroll run	A five-step guide, Calculate and Recalculate, the results table, the register and CSV, and Finalize.	Read; accountant runs; admin finalizes
	Approvals	Rows that broke a rule, with the reason. Open a row, read the full breakdown, approve or reject with a note. Recent decisions are listed below.	Accountant, admin
	Payslips	Every payslip for the month, each openable and printable, or all at once.	All
People	Employees	The staff list with position, hub, reports to, pay setup and bank status. Add and edit people. Each profile shows pay history, team and a change log.	All read; hub manager, accountant, admin edit
	Hubs	The branches and their business.	All read; accountant, admin edit
Insights	Reports	Commission, stock and balances reports.	All
	Audit trail	Every change after first save: who, when, old and new values. Filter and export.	All
Administration	Users and roles	Add users, choose roles and hubs, reset passwords, disable accounts.	Admin
	Settings	Company details, company return rate, review thresholds, closed weekdays, pay defaults by position, session length, and a full backup download.	Admin
Account	My account	Change your own password.	All

Other behaviour worth knowing. Choosing a month in the top bar changes every page. The "Enter data" step on Payroll run reports days with no entry, using the closed weekdays in Settings. Pages a role cannot open show a clear "No access" page instead of loading.

6 How pay is worked out

A guy, supervisor or group manager (monthly)

Step	Rule
Target	Set per person; position defaults are 100,000, 120,000 and 150,000.
Under or on target	Commission = 25% of all business. No basic pay.
Over target	Basic pay + 30% of the business above target. Exactly on target counts as under.
Food	150 a day for each day with an entry, paid only if the person worked at least the position's minimum days (0 for distributors, 24 for supervisors).
Allowances	Added to earnings.
Settle-up	Business minus the amount handed in, each day.
Stock shortfall	Missing pieces times unit price, added to the settle-up deduction.
Personal minus	Advances and personal deductions entered on the daily sheet.
Security	1% of business by default, with an optional cap (a rule can also be fixed, % of gross or % of basic).
Net pay	Gross earnings minus total deductions.
Debt	A negative net pay is carried forward and reduces the next payment. A positive one is paid out.



The line has no jump at the target: at exactly 100,000 both rules give 25,000. Your Excel month sheet wrote the same thing a different way (25% of all business plus 5% of the extra). The two agree once the target is met; under target the month sheet took off 5% of the shortfall and the payslip did not, which the system resolves to the payslip rule.

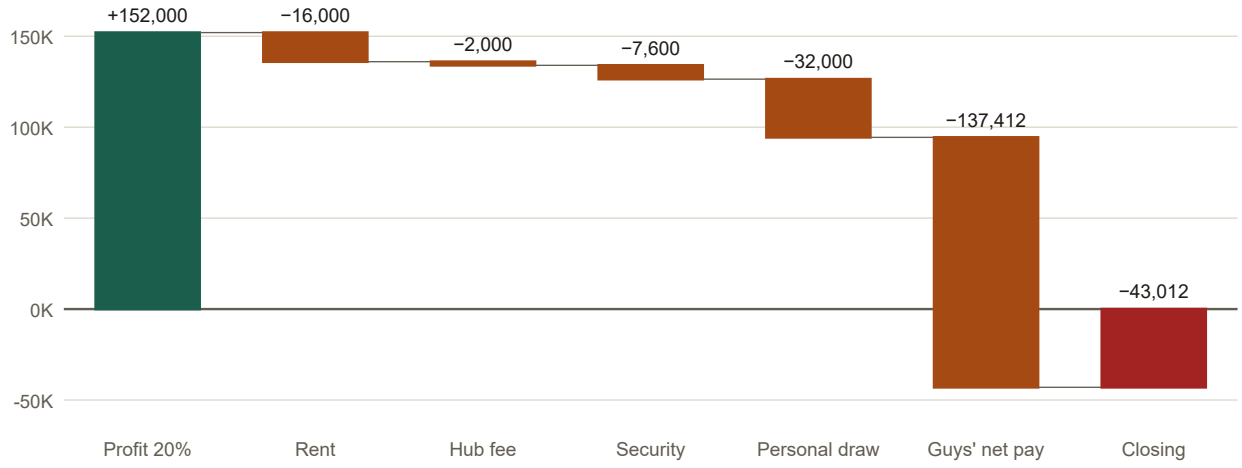
Worked example: Pavan Kumar, distributor, October

Line	Working	Amount
Business	27 days at 4,600	124,200.00
Basic pay	over the 100,000 target	25,000.00
Over-target income	30% of 24,200	7,260.00
Food	27 days at 150	4,050.00
Gross earnings		**36,310.00**
Settle-up	124,200 less 114,264 handed in	−9,936.00
Security	1% of 124,200	−1,242.00
Net pay	36,310 less 11,178	**25,132.00**

A manager (monthly, built from the weekly rows)

Each week: **business x profit % − rent − hub fee − security − personal draw**. Each month: **opening balance + the weeks − company return − the guys' net salaries** in the manager's chain. The result is carried as a running balance. The company return rate is set to 0 in the trial because the Excel files show none.

ARUN SELVAM, OCTOBER: ONE MANAGER'S MONTH (Rs)



Arun's 760,000 of business gives a 152,000 profit share. His costs total 57,600. The seven people in his chain are charged to him at their net pay, 137,412 in all. He closes at minus 43,012, which is carried into November.

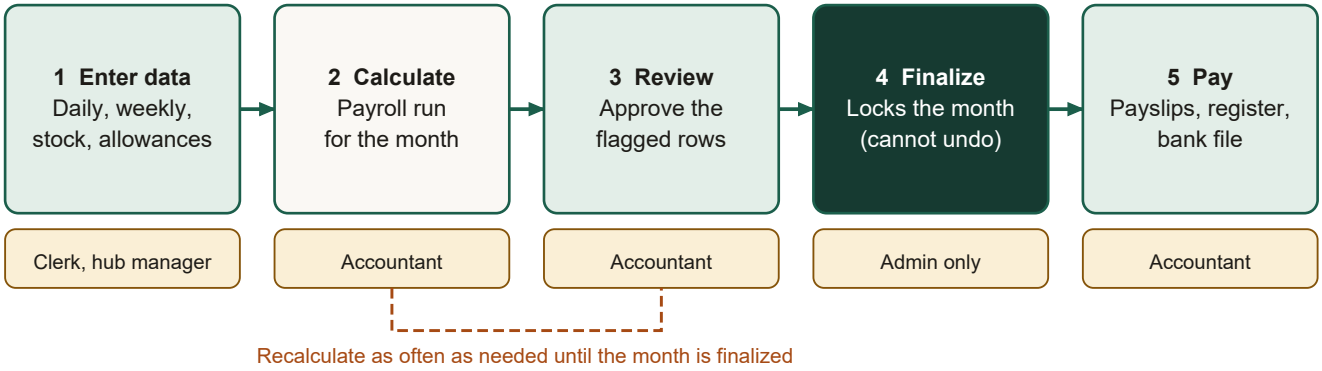
What waits for a second person

Check	Why it matters
Net pay moved more than 20% from last month	Catches typing mistakes and missing days.
Deductions exceed gross earnings	The person would be paid nothing and owe money.
A negative deduction line	A deduction that adds money is usually a typing error.
Stock shortfall above Rs 5,000 a month	Large shortages should be seen before they are charged.
Bank account changed since last verified	A common fraud route; someone else must approve it.
Manager balance going further negative	Shows a branch that is losing money.

The 20% and the Rs 5,000 can be changed in Settings. Approving a row records who, when and a note.

7 The monthly workflow

ONE MONTH, FROM SHEETS TO MONEY



Step	Who	What happens	What the system checks
Enter data	Clerk or hub manager; accountant	Daily sheets (typed or imported), weekly sheets, stock counts, allowances.	A clerk cannot enter for another hub. A finalized month refuses changes.
Calculate	Accountant	Payroll run, then Calculate. Safe to repeat.	Builds every person's earnings, deductions, debt carried in and balance.
Review	Accountant	Approvals lists only the flagged rows, with the reason. Open, read, approve or reject.	Finalizing is refused while anything needs review.
Finalize	Admin	One button. The month is recalculated one last time and locked.	Closing balances become next month's opening balances.
Pay	Accountant	Payslips, the register CSV and the bank file.	The bank file needs a finalized month and earlier months finalized first. People with a negative result are not paid.

Going live: starting balances

The first month has no earlier month to carry from. Each person has an optional **Balance brought forward** on their form. Enter a manager's last master balance, or money a guy still owes as a negative number. It is used only until the person's first calculated month; after that the previous closing balance is always used.

Correcting a mistake

- Before finalizing: fix the sheet and press Recalculate. A rejected row is simply corrected and recalculated.
- After finalizing: the month stays locked. Corrections go into the next month as an allowance or a personal minus.

8 The data model

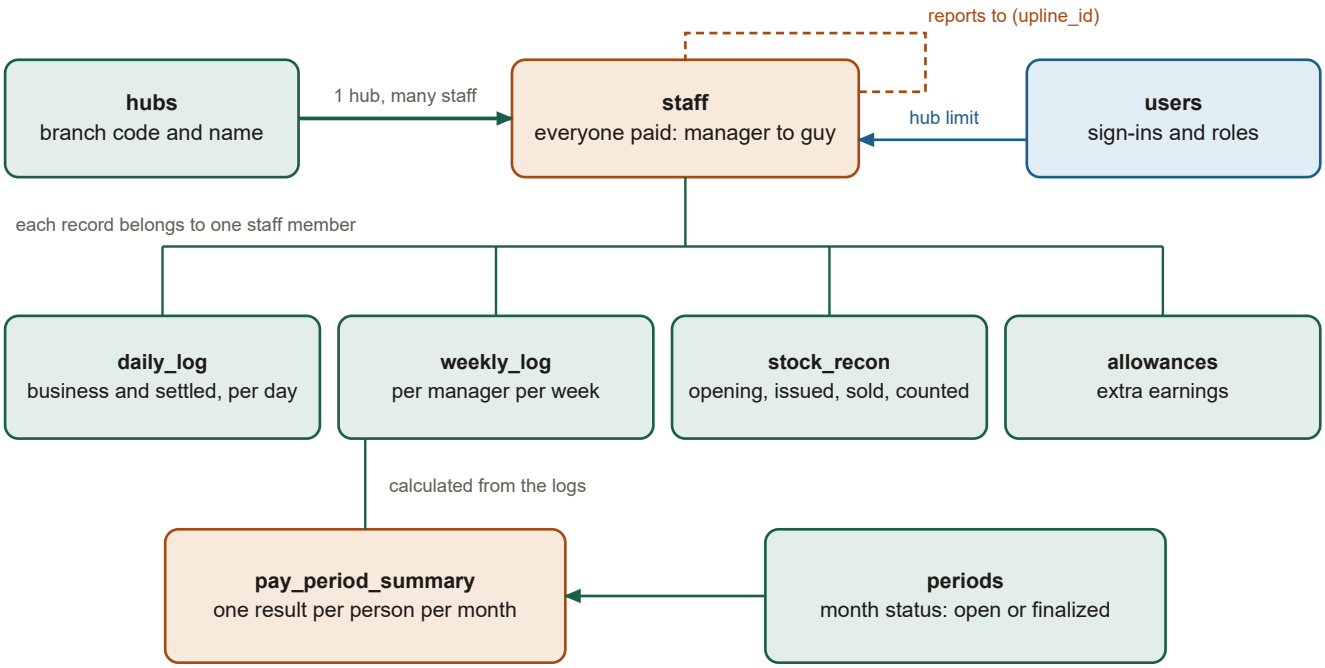


Table	Holds	Key points
hubs	Branches	A short unique code such as J1.
staff	Every paid person	Role (guy or manager), staff_level (distributor to manager), upline_id, derived manager_id, pay setup, security rule, opening balance, bank details, status.
users	Sign-ins	Role, optional hub, scrypt-hashed password, failed-attempt lock.
daily_log	Business, settled, personal minus	One row per person per day. Settle-up minus is computed.
weekly_log	Manager's week	Business, profit %, rent, hub fee, security, personal draw.
stock_recon	Stock lines	Opening, issued, sold, counted, unit price; shortfall computed.
allowances	Extra earnings	Per person per month with a description.
pay_period_summary	The result	One row per person per month: earnings, deductions, net, paid, closing, flags, full breakdown.
periods	Month status	Open or finalized. A finalized month cannot be edited.
audit_log, settings, sessions	Trail, rules, sign-ins	Changes are logged by database triggers so the application cannot forget.

All money is stored in cents as whole numbers, so adding thousands of rows never produces rounding drift.

9 The trial scenario: one group, from fresh

To check the whole process, one manager and seven people were entered into an empty system and taken through October and into November. Every net pay was compared with the payslip rule from your Excel files, and all of them matched to the cent. The same run is described step by step in TRIAL-WALKTHROUGH.md.

The people and what they did in October

ID	Name	Position	Reports to	Days	Per day	Month business
M01	Arun Selvam	Manager	none	weekly	–	760,000 (weekly sheets)
GM01	Meena Rajan	Group manager	M01	27	8,000	216,000
S01	Kavin Thirumal	Supervisor	GM01	27	7,000	189,000
S02	Nila Sivakumar	Supervisor	GM01	27	4,200	113,400
D01	Pavan Kumar	Distributor	S01	27	4,600	124,200
D02	Thevi Ganesh	Distributor	S01	27	3,000	81,000
D03	Sharan Raj	Distributor	S02	12	3,300	39,600
D04	Anitha Jegan	Distributor	S02	6	1,500	9,000

Everyone hands in 92% of their business. Sharan takes a Rs 15,000 advance on 1 October. Sundays are closed. The same chain diagram appears in section 3.

The steps, who did them, and what happened

#	Signed in as	What was done	Result
1	first page	Created the owner account.	Empty dashboard, everything zero.
2	admin	Settings: company name; pay defaults for the three positions; company return 0.	Saved.
3	admin	Hubs: Jaffna 01 and Jaffna 02.	Two hubs.
4	admin	Users: an accountant, a hub manager (J1), a clerk (J1), a viewer.	All five roles had one user. A manager without a hub is refused.
5	admin	Added Arun as Manager of J1.	Reports to is greyed out at the top of the chain.
6	hub manager	Registered the seven people, choosing position and reports to.	Hub locked to J1; pay rules filled in automatically; only 8 people visible.
7	clerk	Daily sheet, Import CSV, 153 rows for October.	153 added; settle-up minus calculated.
8	hub manager	Weekly sheet, four weeks: 190,000 business, 20% profit, rent 4,000, hub fee 500, security 1,900, draw 8,000.	Weekly balance 23,600 each; month 94,400.
9	clerk	Stock: Shine, 850 each. Pavan counted right; Thevi was 3 short.	Shortfall 2,550 for Thevi.
10	accountant	Allowance: Kavin, transport, 3,000.	Saved.
11	accountant	Payroll run, Calculate.	8 people: 6 auto-approved, 2 flagged.
12	accountant	Reviewed Sharan (deductions exceed gross) and Arun (balance deeper negative); approved both with notes.	Queue empty; decisions listed with who and when.
13	accountant, then admin	The accountant had no Finalize button. The owner finalized.	October locked.

#	Signed in as	What was done	Result
14	admin	Payslips, register and bank file.	6 payments, Rs 144,276.00.
15	admin	Dashboard and audit trail.	Business 760K, balance minus 43.0K; actions recorded.
16	clerk, accountant	November: 5 days each for S01, D01, D03; Calculate.	Sharan opens at minus 6,864 and closes at minus 2,114.

The results

Person	Gross	Deductions	Net pay	What explains it
GM01 Meena	58,850	19,440	39,410	Over target: basic 35,000 + 30% of 66,000; food 27 days.
S01 Kavin	57,750	17,010	40,740	Over target; 3,000 allowance; food paid (27 days is at least 24).
S02 Nila	32,400	10,206	22,194	Under target: 25% of 113,400; food paid.
D01 Pavan	36,310	11,178	25,132	Over target: basic 25,000 + 30% of 24,200; food 27 days.
D02 Thevi	24,300	9,840	14,460	Under target; stock shortfall 2,550 taken off.
D03 Sharan	11,700	18,564	−6,864	The 15,000 advance makes it negative; flagged; carried to November.
D04 Anitha	3,150	810	2,340	Only 6 days worked.
M01 Arun	152,000	195,012	−43,012	Profit 152,000; costs 57,600; guys' net pay 137,412; flagged.

Totals	Amount
Guys' business	772,200
Gross earnings (guys)	224,460.00
Deductions (guys)	87,048.00
Paid to the bank (6 people)	144,276.00
Manager's closing balance	−43,012.00

The bank file, as the bank would receive it

Seq	Beneficiary	Bank	Branch	Account	Amount (LKR)	Reference
1	Pavan Kumar	7010	001	1000000104	25,132.00	SAL 2026-10
2	Thevi Ganesh	7010	001	1000000105	14,460.00	SAL 2026-10
3	Anitha Jegan	7010	001	1000000107	2,340.00	SAL 2026-10
4	Meena Rajan	7010	001	1000000101	39,410.00	SAL 2026-10
5	Kavin Thirumal	7010	001	1000000102	40,740.00	SAL 2026-10
6	Nila Sivakumar	7010	001	1000000103	22,194.00	SAL 2026-10
	TOTAL				144,276.00	6 payments

Sharan and Arun are correctly not in the file: both have a negative balance, so there is nothing to pay. The bank format is a placeholder until the real bank's layout is supplied.

November: the carry-over

Person	Opening	Net this month	Paid to bank	Closing
D03 Sharan	−6,864.00	4,750.00	0.00	−2,114.00
M01 Arun	−43,012.00	−13,500.00	0.00	−56,512.00
D01 Pavan	0.00	4,750.00	4,750.00	0.00
S01 Kavin	0.00	4,000.00	4,000.00	0.00

Everyone was flagged for review in November because only five days were entered, so net pay fell more than 20% from October. That is the check working as designed.

10 What your Excel files taught us

Ten workbooks were read in full: 55 weekly masters (about 20 holding real September figures), 21 monthly manager sheets, and 14 guy income sheets with real data. Findings and how the system treats them:

Finding in the files	What the system does
Manager profit is 10%, 15% or 20% of business depending on the sheet (4, 19 and 32 of 55 masters).	Profit % is entered per manager per week, so each manager can have their own rate.
The month sheet uses 20% from Rs 100,000 of weekly business and 15% below (3 sheets use 10%).	Not automatic. The rate is typed per week until the owner confirms the rule.
The 90% hand-in: the master prices everything at 90% of list and divides by 0.9 to get business.	Business is entered directly; the hand-in is the settled amount on each sheet.
The 0.75 and 0.9 in cell E7 change nothing; prices are typed.	No such factor exists. Prices live on the stock line, not in a formula.
Over target: 25,000 or 30,000 basic plus 30% of the extra equals the month sheet's 25% of all plus 5% of the extra.	One rule, the payslip rule. The 5% on a shortfall is not applied.
Food: 150 a day; supervisors only after 24 days, distributors always.	Food per day and the minimum days are per-position settings.
Security is 1% of business, for guys and managers.	A security rule per person, 1% of business by default, with an optional cap.
Rent 4,000 and hub fee 500 appear on only some masters.	Rent and hub fee are entered per manager per week.
The word "supervior" drives the pay formula.	Position is a fixed list, so a spelling mistake cannot change pay.
Prices differ between masters and between columns of one sheet.	Unit price is entered on the stock line and used for that line only. One price list is still needed.
Every guy has 5% to 13% of business deducted as settle-up, even good ones.	Settle-up is business minus handed in, exactly as the sheets do. Whether this includes the normal margin is an owner question.
No employee IDs, and names are spelled several ways.	Every person gets a unique ID and one record.
No group manager appears anywhere.	The level exists, with placeholder pay, until the owner explains it.

11 Hosting, speed and safety

Where it runs

Item	Detail
Hosted app	Vercel project payroll-system-luggo, https://payroll-system-luggo.vercel.app
Hosted database	Neon Postgres in Singapore
Source code	github.com/BRAYNKANTH/payroll-system, branch master
Local	npm run demo (port 8090, demo data) and npm run trial (port 8091, empty)

The speed problem and the fix

The hosted site was slow because its code ran in the US while the database is in Singapore. Every database question crossed the Pacific, and the dashboard asks many in sequence. One setting in vercel.json now runs the code in Singapore beside the database.

Page	Before	After
Health check	0.7 s	about 0.3 s
Dashboard	3.4 s	about 0.33 s
Payroll month	about 1.5 s	about 0.3 s
Daily sheets	about 1.7 s	about 0.4 s
People list	about 1.0 s	about 0.3 s

The hosted demo data

The hosted database holds the owner's admin account plus mock data: three branches, 24 people in the real chain, four finalized months and an open month with exceptions. The mock data should be cleared before real use. The seed refuses to run on a database that already has staff.

Quality checks

- **39 automated tests** cover the pay engine, flags, roles and hub limits, the chain rules, opening balances and the month workflow.
- **An end-to-end run of 39 checks** drove the real API through the trial in section 9 and compared each net pay with the Excel rule.
- **A permission audit** tried every read and write for five roles.
- **Layout checks** looked at 17 screens on a laptop, a phone and in dark mode.

Bugs found and fixed while testing

Bug	Effect	Fix
Stock grid lost typing	Text typed in a row vanished when Add line was clicked.	Each row keeps a draft of what was typed.
Stacked click handlers	On Approvals, Hubs and Allowances a second panel opened after a save, and a delete could be sent twice.	The handler is replaced, not added again.
Profile page error	A formatting slip broke the employee profile during a design clean-up; caught and fixed before it was published.	Corrected, and every page re-checked.
Large figures wrapped	Payroll cards split numbers like 696,442.00 over two lines.	Short headline figure, exact amount underneath.

12 Limits and next steps

Not built or not decided

Item	Why	Needs
Team earnings up the chain	The owner has not given the percentages or the rule for differences versus full rates.	Owner answers (questionnaire section on team earnings)
Group manager pay	Figures are placeholders.	Owner confirms target, basic, food
Company return	The Excel files show none; the old default was 15%.	Owner confirms it exists or not
Bank file format	Generic CSV placeholder.	The bank's real layout
Paid status	The system records the bank file, not whether each person was actually paid.	Decide cash or transfer, and who confirms
One price list	Prices differ between sheets.	The official list and its change rule
Joined and left dates	Part-month staff show as missing days.	A small feature once the owner decides how to treat part months
Hub managers only see hubs; supervisors see nothing extra	Supervisors and group managers have no login role.	Decide if they should see their teams

Housekeeping

- **Rotate the Neon database password.** The connection string was pasted into a chat twice. Reset it in Neon, update DATABASE_URL in Vercel and redeploy.
- **Clear the mock data** from the hosted database before entering real people.
- **Use the questionnaires.** Three documents were prepared: simple English, Tamil, and one with the findings from the Excel files.
- **Payslip wording.** A payslip labels a distributor as "Guy / Supervisor"; it should show the real position.
- **Audit trail.** It records changes, not additions; who added someone is shown on their record as Added by.

13 Quick reference

Commands

Command	What it does
npm install	Installs the dependencies once.
npm run demo	Fills a demo database with three branches of mock people and starts it at http://localhost:8090.
npm run trial	Starts an empty database at http://localhost:8091 for a from-scratch trial. Delete the data\trial folder to start over.
npm test	Runs the 39 automated tests (about a minute).
node seed.js --yes	With DATABASE_URL set to a hosted database, adds the mock data there. Asks for --yes first and refuses a database that already has staff.

Where things are

File	Contents
server.js, api/index.js	The API routes and the Vercel entry point.
auth.js	Users, passwords, sessions and role permissions.
service.js	Entry validation, the monthly run, approvals, reports and settings.
engine.js	The pay rules for guys and managers, and the review flags.
db.js	The database schema, migrations and connections.
reports.js	Payslips, register, and bank file.
seed.js	The demo data.
public/	The browser app: index.html, css/app.css, js/app.js and js/pages/*.js.
DESIGN-SYSTEM.md, TRIAL-WALKTHROUGH.md, HANDOVER.md, README.md	Design rules, the trial guide, the project handover, and setup notes.

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Hub	A branch, such as Jaffna 01.
Position	A person's place in the chain: distributor, supervisor, group manager, manager.
Login role	What someone may do in the system: viewer, clerk, hub manager, accountant, admin.
Upline	The person someone reports to.
Settle-up	Business money handed in at the end of the day. Settle-up minus is business minus handed in.
Target	The monthly sales goal; going over it changes how pay is worked out.
Finalize	Locking a month so nothing in it can change.
Flag	A reason a payroll row needs a second person to look at it.
Opening and closing balance	Money carried between months. Negative means money owed.